

Dates, deadlines, and durations

Teaching guide

Distinguish a deadline from a continuing period.

Understand the distinction

Use on with a date, in with a month or year, and at with an exact time. Write the month name when a numeric date might be ambiguous across countries: 6 September 2026.

By Friday means no later than Friday. Until Friday means continuing up to Friday. Since identifies a starting point; for gives a duration. A deadline may need a time and time zone to be clear.

Compare the patterns

DEADLINE

Send the form by Friday at noon.

Friday at noon is the latest time.

CONTINUATION

The office is closed until Friday.

The closed state continues up to Friday.

DURATION

I have lived here for two years.

Two years measures the period.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. The appointment is ___ 6 September.

A. in

B. on

C. at

2. Which means no later than: by Friday / until Friday?

A. until Friday

B. by Friday

C. Both phrases always set the same deadline.

3. Complete: I have worked here ___ 2024.

A. during

B. for

C. since

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You need one reply no later than 3 p.m. New York time on 10 September. Which deadline is clear?

- A. Please reply by 10 September at 3 p.m. New York time.
- B. Please reply on 10 September at three.
- C. Please reply until 10 September at 3 p.m. New York time.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. on

Use on with a particular date.

A: Use on for a specific date; in fits a month or year.

C: At fits a clock time, not the date 6 September.

2. B. by Friday

Until describes a continuing action or state.

A: Until gives the end of a continuing period. By gives a deadline.

C: By and until differ: a deadline versus the end of a continuing period.

3. C. since

The year is a starting point.

A: During identifies a period, whereas since identifies the starting point here.

B: For gives a duration such as two years; 2024 is a starting point.

4. A. Please reply by 10 September at 3 p.m. New York time.

By gives the latest allowed time, including date and time zone.

B: This leaves a.m./p.m. and the time zone unspecified.

C: Until suggests continuing over a period rather than the deadline for one reply.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-15.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You need one reply no later than 3 p.m. New York time on 10 September. Which deadline is clear?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.